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Reading Response #5: AI-induced Sexual Harassment: Investigating Contextual Characteristics and User Reactions of Sexual Harassment by a Companion Chatbot - Namvarpour et al.

Summary: Goals: This study investigates the phenomenon of AI-induced sexual harassment within the chatbot Replika, aiming to identify key contextual characteristics like unsolicited advances and persistent inappropriate behavior. The researchers explore the disconnect between the app's stated goal of supporting emotional well-being and the actual user outcomes of distress and discomfort. **Takeaways:** The authors suggest that while users expected a platonic AI companion, they often faced a failure to respect boundaries, leading to fears of being monitored without consent. They found that these interactions often resulted in emotional distress rather than support. **Strengths:** A major strength is the study's focus on surveying emotional reactions; given that Replika markets itself as a tool for mental wellness, understanding the specific emotional toll of these "unexpected" sexual advances is vital to evaluating its success. **Weaknesses:** The reliance on existing App Store reviews limits the findings to a specific subset of users. But, the authors admit that a significant limitation regarding the exclusion of longer reviews is due to "tokenization costs." I think this is a major oversight, as those longer reviews likely contained the most useful qualitative data. Also, by only using negative sentiment reviews, they potentially missed how positive reviews might reveal normalized problematic behaviors... **Questions:** One main question I have concerns RQ1: what specifically constitutes "sexual harassment" from a chatbot in the eyes of a user versus a developer? I also wonder if Replika's behavior is just a mirror of how people connect online, or if it is a deliberate design choice to appeal to a specific male demographic via a "freemium" model?

Reaction: Interesting Parts: I was specifically reminded of an experience I had a few years ago at a "Human Connection and AI Summit" with the Rithm Project, where we were instructed to use Replika for a few days to prep for a convo about chatbots. I found today's paper validating because it confirmed my own experiences; I experienced incessant flirting, ignorance of my refusals, and unprompted romantic/suggestive photos. I also thought the point about "unexpected, surprising responses" was interesting—I wonder if that element of surprise is exactly what makes the app attractive to some users, creating a conflict between safety and engagement. **Applications:** I think this informs inclusive design by shifting the burden of safety to the company rather than the user. We cannot rely on users to "train" the bot out of harassment; instead, we need safeguards like "Interactive Memory Management" or "Memory Sandboxes" that give users control over what the AI remembers. Overall, I think we need to treat these applications as research subjects requiring ethical safeguards rather than just consumer products.